We won the toss and decided to bat first at Eden Park in Auckland, a world-famous venue designed for rugby and being used for one of the biggest matches in cricket. The straight boundaries were unusually short but we had played here many times before, had prepared carefully and were happy with our plans ...

Hashim and Quinton open our innings. Quinton is dropped in the second over, and then Hash is dropped in the third over. Maybe this is going to be our day, after all, but both fall soon afterwards and, from 31 for two, Faf du Plessis and Rilee Rossouw settle into a rhythm and start to make progress. The intensity of the contest is remarkable. Brendon McCullum, the brilliant Kiwi captain, is trying everything. We are fighting hard.

Rilee falls for 39, and I walk out to join Faf at the crease at 114 for three in the 27th over. Here we are again, my old friend from Affies and me, together again, in the heat of the battle. Corey Anderson bowls, short and rising, and my first ball deflects down off my gloves and narrowly misses my off stump. Breathe hard.

We settle and start to ease on the accelerator, taking 11 runs from the 31st over, 11 from the 32nd, another 11 from the 33rd, 13 from the 34th. We seem to be taking control, applying the pressure. I push into the covers and call Faf for a quick single. It's going to be tight, and I sprint as fast as I can and I dive at full length, getting an eyeful of dirt in the process. The throw misses the stumps, although I think I would have been safe anyway ... and then I guide the last ball of the over past third man for four.

In the 35th over, I cut firmly square of the wicket but too high and the ball is flying straight at Kane Williamson, fielding at point, and my heart skips a beat as the ball bursts through his hands and falls to the grass. I survive ... and pull the next ball for six, drive the next for four and drive the next for another four. We are racing along, daring to believe that this may turn out to be our day after all, and we reach 216 for three at the